

It is natural that the worst financial collapse in the world's history should set a high record for money losses. The average man prefers to hear in detail how, why and when money is lost, rather than to listen to old proverbs about the evanescence of riches, but about the only point on which all commentators on the world depression agree is that many millions of people have lost many millions of dollars. Of course, the same people lost many other things as well, for the revenge that easy money takes on its temporary possessor is that, when it leaves him, after a boom, it carries away skin as well as securities, vanity as well as values. Some part of the loser always manages to adhere to the departing dollar—a fact well known to the maimed victims. Two years ago the vast army of greed-stricken Americans, male and female, who lost billions when the bull market ended were called silly asses for thinking they could get something for nothing—fools who deserved to lose because they violated the fundamental principles of the ancient art of making money the moment they tried to play the other man's game. Now we see that if poor fools lost in 1929, the wise rich lost in 1931. Nobody escaped. It was a lesson for everybody to learn—and we have learned it.

From the peak in 1929 to the low of December of the same year, the shrinkage in the market value of stocks dealt in on the New York Stock Exchange amounted to more than \$26,000,000,000. From the peak of the boom to the low of 1931, the shrinkage in the same stocks amounted to nearly \$60,000,000,000. From the high of 1930 to the low of 1931, it was about \$45,000,000,000. The shrinkage in 1929 from peak to bottom in listed bonds, in which poor fools didn't gamble, was less than \$1,000,000,000, but from September, 1930, to December, 1931, the difference exceeded \$10,000,000,000. In bonds, remember! In other words, from the height of the speculative madness to the time when the poor pikers were eliminated, the total loss was only about \$27,000,000,000 in both stocks and bonds on the New York Stock Exchange. But from the spring of 1930 to the end of 1931, or after the little fellow had been